

Amazon's grocery delivery

Amazon is doing an internal testing of a free grocery delivery service in the USA and the program goes by the name AmazonTote

NFC on iPhone 5 and iPad 2

Near Field Communication, a short range high frequency wireless communication is rumoured to be found on iPad 2 and iPhone 5

Why Indians don't buy online?

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Perhaps, it is justified to compare online shopping with online dating. After all, only those of us, who have experience of the Internet and are trustful of the way the myriad online entities are managed, will be inclined to discover a new relationship or strike a new bargain through a click of the mouse. In Western countries, online dating is considered to be a phenomenal success, but in India such websites have a rather lukewarm response. Same is the case with online shopping.

Indians might buy online once in a while, but bulk of their purchases always happen in conventional stores built from brick and mortar. On our Facebook community, we posted the question to our members if they preferred online shopping. The result was an engaging discussion. Gourav Kumar says, "People still prefer to buy in shops as they can see the product and talk to the shopkeeper." This might as well be true. Indians are convivial by nature and they might be less inclined to buy in situations where they can't have a direct interaction with the shopkeeper.

Shopping is not only about getting new things into your life; it can also be an activity with some social aspects. A walk into the neighbourhood shop, where you can exchange local gossip, might cheer you more as compared to sitting on your computer and tapping the right keys for making a purchase. But it is also true that online shopping saves you time and it might even be cheaper. Smiriti Khanna, a college student in Delhi, prefers to buy her books online. "Online buying is saving me time and money," she says. "Before buying any book, I can compare the rates

By nature most Indians are not inclined towards a profligate lifestyle; we would rather save money than splurge. So how do online retailers make a mark in a nation that is so fiscally conservative? There are no easy solutions in sight

from different websites and buy from where the prices are lowest." However, for buying everything other than books, she prefers retail outlets of the real world. "I won't think of buying a new dress online, or even a new electronic device," she explains. "You need to examine such items before buying. Shopping at a nice mall is much more visual and fluid and entertaining."

Are we innovative enough?

One of the reasons why many Indians don't find shopping online to be "visual and fluid and entertaining," as Smiriti has put it, is because a lot of exciting stuff is not even listed in the catalogue of our online retailers. We don't have any online retailer in India whose range of offers is even remotely comparable to what the likes of Amazon, eBay and Best Buy offer in western countries. If you look at the merchandise being offered by all these

websites, then you can't stop yourself from having the feeling of déjà vu. There is not enough novelty and innovation happening to make the online shopping experience more satisfying, cheaper and entertaining for the consumer. In USA, during this holiday season, people



Ebay online is one of the oldest online shopping players

purchased an average of four Ferraris online from eBay by using their mobile phones. That says a lot about the degree of trust that Americans have for eBay and other major online retailers.

The Indian consumer is deeply traditional in nature, and that makes it very difficult for even the most determined players to crack open the lucrative retail market. And it must be even tougher if you are an online retailer. However, during the past few years a large number of multi-brand online retailers have made a foray into the market. All of them have very mediocre results in terms of traffic, as well as orders. The entrants include eBay, HomeShop18, Flipkart, India Plaza, Rediff Shopping, India-times Shopping, Future Bazaar, and few others. All of these companies are being backed by well funded industrial houses, which can afford to keep the online business going, in hope that few years down the line the elusive consumers will start arriving by the droves

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Gourav Kumar, College Student